

Report Summary: 0036. TLP: CLEAR			Date	Breakout Scale
Title	EU	Chinese State Media Violating Meta Ad Policy in Europe	18/12/2024	2

Summary

- Between Dec 2023 and Nov 2024 Chinese state-controlled media published 101 ads targeting Europe, 26 being unlabelled ads on social, political, and election-related topics.
- The ads promoted China's relationship with different parts of the world and discredited China's adversaries.
- 809,040 European users were reached by the ads.
- The ads used memes, co-opted trusted individuals, and partially concealed their sponsorship.
- Meta and European Governments alerted. Meta should monitor authoritarian state-controlled media activities.

Incident

Between December 2023 and November 2024, the Chinese state-controlled media Global Times and CGTN's European branch posted 101 ads targeting EU countries. Of these, 26 were unlabelled political ads, likely violating Meta's policy.

The Global Times has been called China's Fox News and is an avenue of influence used by the CCP to reach English-speaking audiences (1). The tabloid often uses threatening and aggressive tones on some sensitive topics such as Taiwanese sovereignty (2).

China Global Television Network (CGTN) is a branch of the Chinese state-controlled media company China Media Group, which is under the authority of China's State Council (3). The TV channel has an extensive network of influencers and social media channels in a wide variety of languages (4, 5, 6). CGTN could be equated to China's RT.

Narrative

China and the EU as partners; China as a force for development in Africa; U.S. a threat to Asian security; Japanese nuclear waste water, Western countries as aggressors and China as peacemakers; Sanctions on Russia prevent nuanced information on Russian invasion of Ukraine; China's green development; Chinese Cultural unity.

Impact

The ads reached a total 809,040 European users. We see indicators that a large portion of the ads also targeted people outside the EU. Ads covering elections, social and political issues reached 271,000 European users.

Key Objectives and Behaviours (DISARM Red Framework) (Max 2 objectives and 4 TTPs).

- Objective: [Defend Reputation](#) and [Smear](#) – counter-narratives to dismiss criticism and attack their opponents.
- [Purchase Targeted Advertisements](#) – The pages purchased ads to deliver their content to European audiences.
 - [Develop Memes](#) – Global Times used memes in their ad campaigns.
 - [Co-Opt Trusted Individuals](#) – Ads from both entities used scholars and experts to deliver their operational narratives.
 - [News Outlet Persona](#) – China has positioned these two influence operations as news outlets.
 - [Conceal Sponsorship](#) – Global Times and CGTN Europe are not filling out the disclaimer required by Meta for advertisers on social issues, elections, and politics, hence not fully declaring who is paying for the ads.

Recommendations and Actions Taken

Actions taken: Alert sent to Meta and European governments - 19/12/2024.

- Meta should have more stringent monitoring of known authoritarian state-controlled media's use of their ads;
- Meta's European ad transparency policy should be extended globally;
- Stricter penalties for continued violations of ad policies like these, keeping the violators accountable.

Report Topic	Evidence	Authors	Content type	Platforms
Link Ads, China, Meta	See Report	Saman Nazari, Alliance4Europe.	Ads	Meta